spells, while the accurate Stuart Clark had the job of trying to keep things tight. To his credit, he also picked up some key wickets.

I went after the bowling from the start of my innings. I was feeling good and was set to kick on for a big score. However, you don't always get a hundred just because you're feeling good and I got out after scoring 62. We were all out for 196, which was nowhere near enough. Australia soon managed to establish a stranglehold over us, eventually winning the Test in four days. It was not the start we had hoped for.

Red faces all round

Something unexpected that I had to deal with at the time of the Melbourne Test was a severe allergic reaction. On our way to Australia, Harbhajan Singh and I had bought a newly launched moisturizing cream at Singapore airport and for the first few days I had no problems using the cream. It was during the first Test that I started feeling a serious burning sensation on my face. Harbhajan did not have any such problem, so at first I attributed my reaction to a massage. I had had to lie down with my face on a towel and I thought it must have been something to do with the detergent used on the towel.

The problem started to bother me on the third day and I remember putting more cream on my face before going to bed, thinking it would help. The next morning I awoke in agony. My face was on fire and it was as if someone had pushed it into a barbecue. It was even worse by the evening with my face all red and swollen. So much so that I was too embarrassed to go out in public and had to hide behind large sunglasses.

Anjali was arriving in Sydney the next day. With the Melbourne Test over on the fourth day, I got permission to fly to Sydney a little earlier than planned and met up with her and the children at the airport. They were horrified by my face and asked what on earth I had done to it. I was not in the best of moods and wanted to get to the hotel as quickly as possible. When we finally arrived, after a forty-five-minute drive because of the traffic, I was really irritable. The hotel staff then took a long time to give us our rooms and I ended up shouting at the hotel manager. By the time we got to the room I had started to feel worse and told Anjali to ask the kids to sit in the adjoining room and leave me alone. The poor kids were wondering what was wrong with me to behave like this. By then, my face was troubling me even more. We called